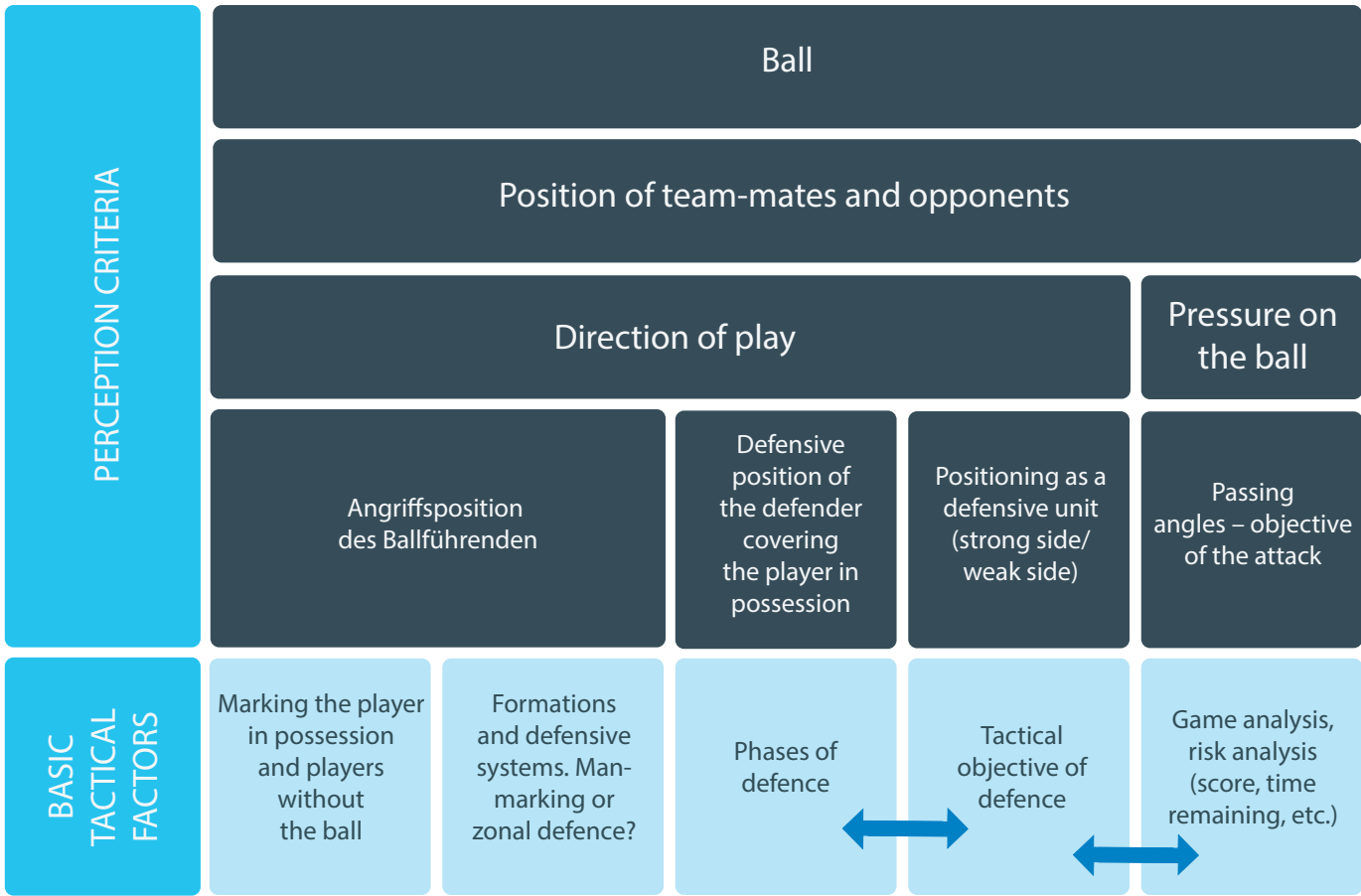


1.3.2 Basic core defensive concepts

Basic core defensive concepts can be defined as a combination of defensive movement, positioning and actions that are individually or collectively executed, according to the defensive aims or objectives (e.g. to recover possession, prevent the opposition from advancing or scoring). It should be noted that all of these core concepts have a tactical objective and are designed to accomplish one of the general principles of defensive play.

These elements and concepts are difficult to separate or classify, due to the group-based nature of the events involved in the defensive process. However, they are all essentially based on perception and decision-making, which are in turn based on the player's analysis of the game situation. As, therefore, their application is determined by the reading of the game and the range of variables and conditioning factors involved, the cognitive aspect of motor ability in each game situation is decisive. As such, it is important to look briefly at the fundamental components of perception and decision-making.

Fundamental components of perception and decision-making



Once we have formed an understanding of the process involved in perception and decision-making, which in turn enable the basic core defensive concepts to be applied, we can then study the key elements which form the basic defensive principles:

1. Elements of man-marking

There are three key phases of man-marking:

Before receiving the ball (or in cases where the ball is not received)	Defensive cover. Basic defensive positioning. Defensive solidity.
	Position one's body in order to gain a visual command of the playing area (the ball and the position of team-mates and opponents).
	Keep a safe distance between oneself and the opponent (to enable a composed reaction prior to any attacking move). Anticipate when defending (defend with one's body between the opponent, closing off any potential passing angles available).
When the ball is being received (while the pass is on its way)	Support, cover, control the space (individually and collectively); 'floating defence'; etc.
	Movement along the trajectory of the pass, close up on the player receiving the ball. Pressure. Aggression.
	Anticipation. Interception on the path of the pass. Defend by anticipating the pass before it is played or position oneself between the ball and the player receiving it while it is on its way.
After the ball has been received (defending against the player in possession)	Body position and controlling of space in relation to the player receiving the pass in a defensive movement. Points to bear in mind: speed of the ball, movements made by the attacking player, stronger foot of the player receiving the ball, reading the game.
	Basic defensive position. Harrying. Tackling. Going shoulder to shoulder with the player on the ball.
	Blocking/interception (breaking up) of passing or shooting angles. Without losing basic defensive position.

2. Controlling the space (when making adjustments)

A key core concept is the ability to control the space in relation to an opponent when making adjustments in terms of marking:

- Keep a clear distance in relation to the opponent being marked (space around the opponent without the ball).
- Control the space around the opponent in possession.
- Recover the defensive space.
- Control space when executing a defensive blocking move.

3. Putting pressure on the ball

A key core concept of defending, on which the other aspects of defending largely depend. The following factors should be taken into account:

- Reducing the defensive space along the path of the pass.
- Basic defensive positioning when pressing.
- Tackling, intercepting, harrying, going shoulder to shoulder with an opponent and anticipating.
- Defensive positioning when pressing, dominating the area around the opponent to reduce space and passing angles.

4. Commanding the space

Rational occupation of space in the defensive line is a basic core concept for any defensive system (including man-marking). There are always defenders who have less of an individual impact than their opponent. They must provide balance to the defence by dominating and closing down the space that the opponent can utilise to create an attacking threat, or by taking up a covering defensive position. The task of commanding the space begins before the team loses possession of the ball by maintaining **defensive balance** when in attack. Once the defensive phase begins and the positional defence is organised, defenders in the second and third defensive lines are required to dominate the space and compensate for the movements and decision-making of the players